

The Leicester Theatre (1800-1835)

J. D. Bennett

On 13th September 1809 Dorothy Jordan, one of the most famous comic actresses of her day, and long-standing mistress to the Duke of Clarence (the future King William IV) wrote to him:

Bull (Bell?) Inn, Leicester, Wednesday, half past one ... I played last night to a full House, which amounted to £60. It is the intrest [sic] of all managers to deceive one in this particular, but as it is impossible to measure the House beforehand, we must submit to the disadvantage, tho' it is a disappointment... (1)

She wrote again the next day

Leicester, Thursday, half past 11... I like the people here very much. The theatre has been full each night, but, as I mentioned in my letter of yesterday, it only holds £60 - so that I made £60. However, that is better than nothing ... I am this moment going to set out [for Liverpool]. (2)

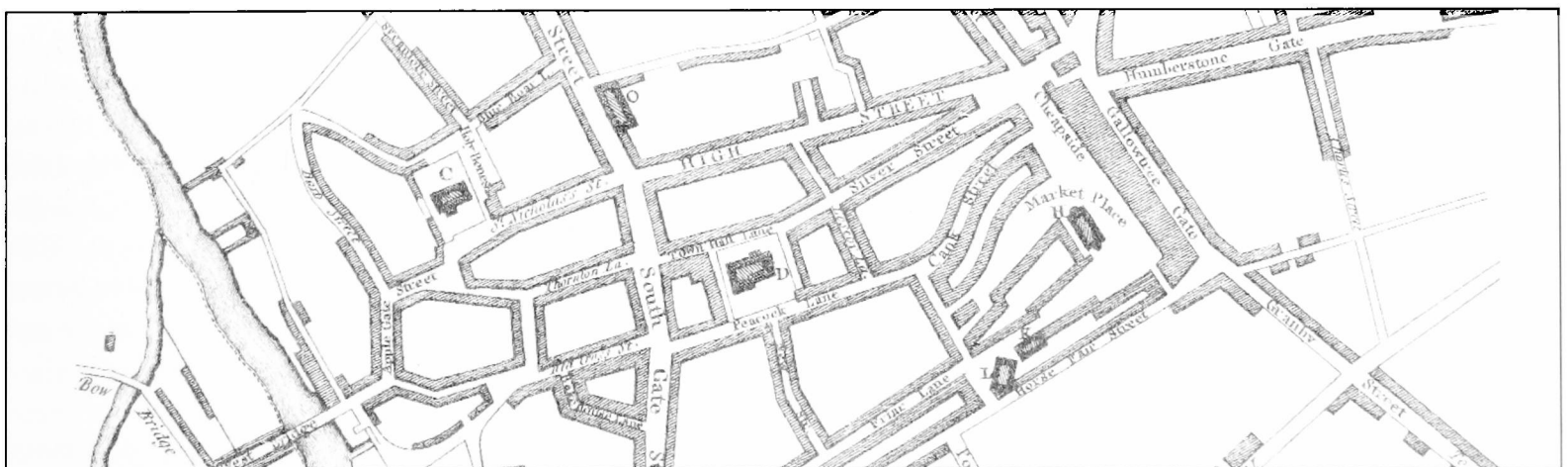
The Leicester theatre which Dorothy refers to was in the Market Place South. It was Leicester's first purpose-built theatre (3) and at the time of Dorothy's performance, barely a decade old. Clearly marked on several maps (4), the theatre adjoined the Assembly Rooms (the present City Rooms), both buildings having been designed by John Johnson. The 'New Theatre' as it was initially known, opened after a delay due to the 'extreme severity of the season', on 17th March 1800. The opening performance was George Colman's *The Heir at Law*, a 'recent' comedy which was performed by a visiting company from the Theatre Royal, Cheltenham. There was also a specially written prologue by 'a YOUNG LADY of Leicester' (who was in a fact Susanna Watts) spoken by Mr Richardson, the acting manager. (5) However, the theatre was initially only open for approximately one week, and then closed until reopening later that year in May.

Although no illustrations of the theatre have been traced to date, contemporary descriptions have survived. A second prologue, this time written by 'a Gentleman of Leicester' (Henry Carter) and probably delivered at the reopening, gives an indication of what the interior of the theatre was like:

*We boast not here a wide extended plain,
Rome's Colosseum or New Drury Lane,
But that our house is just of such a size
That it may please your ears as well as eyes.
Our skilfull Architect delights to grace
With art palladian this his native place. (6)*

The first manager, Mr Watson, who was responsible for a number of other provincial theatres, proudly called it 'as handsome and complete a House, for its size, as any in the country'. (7) Elsewhere, Georgian theatres in market towns were not very large judging by surviving examples at Bury St Edmunds and Richmond, and that at Leicester was no exception. Susanna Watts leaves us the following description in her guidebook of 1804:

A small theatre, built by Mr Johnson, neatly and commodiously fitted up, nearly on the plan of the London houses, furnishes the inhabitants of Leicester with a more complete display of the dramatic art than they had before enjoyed, and has been the means of gratifying them by the talents of several performers of the first-rate excellence. The popular pieces of the London stage are here every season represented in a manner pleasing to the town and honorable to the manager. (8)



Extract from Thomas Combe's *Plan of the Town of Leicester*, 1802 showing the Leicester Theatre of 1800 marked 'K'. (With acknowledgement to Leicester University Press – from Susanna Watts *A Walk Through Leicester*, 1967 fasc. of 1804 ed.)

By 1831, a later writer was less complimentary, calling it 'very small, built entirely of brick, and so extremely plain is its exterior that it nearly approaches to meanness'.(9)

The theatre was open during the winter season, and when the town had more visitors at the time of the Leicester fairs, the assizes and the races. There were usually two different plays every night, the second of which was often a farce, with musicians, dancers or acrobatics to keep the audience entertained during interludes. What we would now regard as marathon performances started at 6.00, 6.30 or 7.00 and ended around midnight, with half-price admission halfway through the evening. At other times there might be touring panoramas, troupes of jugglers, ventriloquists and waxworks to be seen there, with the building also being used for concerts and lectures.

Between 1801 and 1815 the theatre was managed by William Macready, an Irish actor who had previously worked at Covent Garden. Drawing on his London experience and contacts, he was able to introduce new types of scenery, new plays, and persuade many notable actors and actresses to appear at his Leicester theatre.

Dorothy Jordan's two-night engagement in 1809 was one such star performance. She was hugely popular. Audiences 'had a high treat in the transcendent comic talent of Mrs Jordan ... (and the) house each evening was crowded with much of the consequence and fashion of the neighbourhood'. (10) She played in *The Soldier's Daughter*, a patriotic comedy written for her by the actor and dramatist Andrew Cherry at the time of the invasion scare of 1804, and 'an old favourite' - Susannah Centlivre's *The Wonder! A Woman Keeps a Secret*. Dorothy returned to Leicester in 1812 performing in *The Wonder!* and Hannah Cowley's *The Belle's Stratagem*, a late-eighteenth century comedy, and made a final, three-night visit in 1814, when she again appeared in *The Soldier's Daughter*. The programme also included *The Spoiled Child*, a popular farce which she was rumoured to have written herself, in which she played the part of Little Pickle. On this last occasion she attended a

small private dinner party with several well-known Leicester names including Mary Linwood and William Gardiner who had seen her act the previous evening, and also the Rev. Charles Berry of the Leicester Great Meeting.

Another great attraction of the theatre was William Henry West Betty, a child prodigy known as Master Betty or 'The Young Roscius', who had caused a sensation in London playing Shakespearean tragic parts. Charles Macready, the manager's son and a future popular actor, who was at Rugby School at the time, was 'smuggled' out of school and over to

Leicester in a chaise to see the thirteen year-old actor as *King Richard III* in November 1804. Betty returned to Leicester in 1805 and 1806, playing to crowded houses on each occasion.



Dorothy Jordan,
the famous actress and mistress of the Duke
of Clarence, who appeared at the Leicester
Theatre in 1809, 1812 and 1814.

Other famous artistes to appear at the Leicester Theatre included George Frederick Cooke, whom the *Leicester Journal* called 'the greatest actor of the present day' (1808 and 1809), Charles Macready, who had now embarked on a stage career (1812), the famous clown Joseph Grimaldi (1817), the tragedian Edmund Kean (1824 and 1829), the comedian John Liston (1828), Charles Mathews, in one of his famous *At Home* performances (1834), and the singers Madame Catalini (1810) and Madame Vestris (1828).

Throughout the theatre's existence, seat prices remained constant at 1s. for the gallery, 2s. for the pit and 3s. for the boxes. Exceptionally, on a few special occasions, the management felt justified in raising prices - for instance, for Master Betty's visits in 1804, 1805 and 1806, when the gallery was increased to 2s. 6d., and the pit and boxes to 6s., and for Mrs Jordan's visit in 1809, when the gallery was 1s. 6d., the pit 3s. 6d. and the boxes, 5s. When she returned in 1814, however, very near the end of her acting career, it was 'Prices as usual'.

The profits from the opening night in 1800 were distributed among the poor of the town. This philanthropic practice was revived in 1819 when the profits from the last night of the season were presented to Leicester Infirmary, whilst a

company of amateurs gave a special performance in aid of distressed local framework knitters.

As for the fabric of the theatre, it is recorded that in 1802 heating was provided 'by stoves being constantly kept in various parts of the Theatre'. Notable improvements in the 1820s and early 1830s included reports in 1824 that 'A Lobby has been formed at the Box Entrance, some additional lustres have been furnished, together with a quantity of New Scenery and the Old repainted; the former stage lights, so much complained of, have been removed'. In 1826 'A NEW GOLD CURTAIN', which must have looked rather splendid, was installed, and in 1831 the theatre was 'newly painted and embellished'. Two years later the smells and smoke caused by oil lamps were entirely banished, as 'the interior of the theatre ... is now BRILLIANTLY ILLUMINATED WITH GAS'. (11)

THEATRE, LEICESTER.
FOR THE BENEFIT OF
MRS. PARKER COOKE,
AND POSITIVELY THE
LAST NIGHT OF THE SEASON.
MRS. PARKER COOKE,
Most respectfully begs leave to announce that her Benefit will
take place on
MONDAY EVENING,
December 3, 1832, and trusts that the MISFORTUNE OF
BREAKING HER LEG, which deprived her of the honour of
appearing before the Public for nearly the whole Season,
will not prevent her receiving that favour and kindness, which
she experienced when she was before in Leicester, and hopes
the consideration of so serious an accident will induce the
Supporters of the Drama, and her Friends, to come forward
on the present occasion; and, she most earnestly solicits the
Patronage of the Ladies and Gentlemen, and Public of
Leicester.

THE EVENING'S ENTERTAINMENT
To commence with the Favourite PLAY of
EVERY ONE HAS HIS FAULT.
Mrs. Plaid—By Mrs. PARKER COOKE,
(Being her First Appearance since her Accident.)
Edward—Miss Adelaide Cooke.

In the course of the Evening, a variety of Entertainments,
consisting of
THE BROAD SWORD HORNPIPE,
By Miss Corie.
THE COMIC DUET OF
"When a little Farm we keep,"
By Mrs. Parker Cooke, and Mr. Adderley.
A Favorite Song—By Miss Adelaide Cook.
Mr. Adderley will go through the Celebrated Portrai-
tures of the Antique
VENETIAN STATUES,
After the manner of Mr. Ducrow.
Comic Song—Mr. Bristow.

Leicester Theatre programme from 1832 as advertised in the Leicester Journal, 30th November 1832.

After the departure of William Macready, successive theatre managers included Robert Elliston (1817-19) who went on to manage Drury Lane, Mr Raymond in the 1820s, and Belville Penley and James Anderson, who were joint managers from 1831 onwards. However, in spite of the various improvements carried out, these do not seem to have resulted in better audiences, and in 1833 playbills announcing a joint benefit for the managers referred to 'the losses they have sustained during the present season from unforeseen circumstances (and) the expense incurred in

rendering the (theatre) worthy of patronage'. (12) In September 1835 it was announced that 'it is in contemplation, after the present season to pull down the theatre' and to 'build another in its place on an extended scale'. (13) The replacement theatre was well-subscribed to. The 'old' Leicester Theatre closed on 23rd November 1835 and demolition began in March 1836. Its replacement, the much larger Theatre Royal opened later the same year, having been built in record time on part of the same site but with its distinctive Ionic portico frontage facing onto Horsefair Street.

References and Notes:

1. Arthur Aspinall (ed.), *Mrs Jordan and Her Family* (1951), 108. Dorothy Jordan was the Duke of Clarence's mistress for 20 years from 1791 to 1811. She had 10 illegitimate children by him, and when on tour she wrote to him almost every day.
2. Ibid. Notwithstanding Dorothy Jordan's comments, £60 was a useful sum of money in 1809 - the equivalent of more than £4,000 today.
3. From the Restoration to 1750, Leicester Town Hall (the Guildhall) was the main place for actors in Leicester. In 1750 a combined playhouse, concert and assembly rooms was built at Leicester's Haymarket / Coal Hill although by 1800 this venue was increasingly inadequate for theatrical performances. The Bath or Vauxhall Gardens were also periodically used for dramatic entertainment until their closure in the 1790s, this further contributing to the lack of adequate playhouse facilities in Leicester by the turn of the century. The subsequent separate building of the new Assembly Rooms and the new Leicester theatre was deliberate in the hope that both would be more successful as distinct functions. C. J. Billson, *Leicester Memoirs* (1924), 102-109.
4. For example, Thomas Combe's map of 1802 and Ellis's map of 1828.
5. The prologue was printed in the *Leicester Journal*, 28th March 1800.
6. Helen and Richard Leacroft, *The Theatre in Leicestershire* (1986), 15. This second prologue is in the *Leicester Journal*, 9th May 1800. 'New Drury Lane' refers to the new theatre opened in 1794, and burnt down in 1809.
7. Ibid., 15.
8. Susanna Watts, *A Walk through Leicester* (1804), 131-2. Watts' description was reprinted by John Nichols in his *History and Antiquities of the County of Leicester*, vol I, pt ii (1815), 534.
9. J. Curtis, *A Topographical History of the County of Leicester* (1831), 113.
10. Leacroft 1986 op cit., 17.
11. Ibid., 16.
12. C. J. Billson 1924 op. cit., 113.
13. Leacroft 1986 op cit., 25.